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UAE Presidential Court

MOHAMED MEETS EUROPEAN COUNCIL PRESIDENT

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan met Antonio Costa, President of the European Council, yesterday. During the meeting, the two sides discussed developments in the region and their implications for regional and international peace and security, as well as their serious impact on maritime security, energy supplies, and the global economy.

How Dubai communities are helping children find calm

Children don't need fancy outings or dinners; they just want some cheer

DUBAI
BY LAKSHANA N. PALAT
Assistant Features Editor

Children absorb tension from all around them. Even if they cannot fully understand the geopolitics behind it. They don't need to, the expressions on their parents' faces often say enough.

However, parents are made of a different mettle. While comforting their children in the best way that they could, they also found different options to keep them a little busy and tire them out, so that they wouldn't have to constantly worry about the conflict. For instance, 37-year-old Dubai-based Irfan Haider, a



Activities like doodling with paints can offer children a break from stress.

Pakistani expat, decided to enrol his children for swimming classes, in the Star Academy right next door. "It definitely tired them out, and they get to use all their extra energy," he notes.

Football, for sure, can never let your child down. For Dubai-based Nicola Craddock, a mother of two, community support

has made a noticeable difference. Living in Emaar South, she says, the Football Clinic has opened up sessions for children in the neighbourhood, offering a much-needed release. "A local PE teacher is running weekly sessions in our community park for children too," she adds.

In 2020, when the pandemic disrupted daily life, Alisha Prydden-Eason, CEO and co-founder of Oodles of Doodles, was struck by an unusual source of inspiration. Looking for ways to reduce screen time and keep children engaged, she noticed her son Alfie picking up a water bottle and doodling on it. The moment went on to spark a creative concept that has since involved more than 1,500 children through tasting and design workshops.

In the current climate, she says, such creative outlets have taken on added importance.

SEE ALSO P4

Dubai doctors rebuild expat's face

Nose cut, teeth crushed and jaw damaged in accident

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

His nose had been cut, his teeth crushed, his jaw and eye sockets badly damaged, and blood was pooling fast. He could barely breathe. His vision had doubled. One side of his face had begun to lose feeling.

When a 42-year-old Indian expat arrived at the emergency room of Aster Hospital Mankhool in this condition, it was immediately clear to the doctors there that this was a fight for far more than just his face.

What followed was a race against time and a surgical feat that few hospitals in the region could have pulled off.

Doctors quickly identified

the severity of what they were dealing with: pan facial trauma, a rare condition involving fractures across the upper, middle, and lower regions of the face simultaneously.

Extensive damage

For this patient, who did not wish to be identified, the damage was extensive: multiple fractures of the jaw, cheekbones, nasal bones and eye sockets, significant loss of nasal cartilage and teeth, disrupted jaw alignment, and orbital injuries that placed his vision at serious risk.

The surgical team, led by Dr Renju Prem, Lead Surgeon in Oral and Maxillofacial Surgery at Aster Hospital Mankhool, performed a detailed procedure known as Open Reduction and Internal Fixation (ORIF) with multiple orbital reconstructions under general anaesthesia.

The anaesthesia team, in-

cluding Dr Abhishek J Narayan and Dr Jawad Ebn Mohammed, made the critical decision to use sub-mental intubation, given the extensive facial and nasal fractures that ruled out a conventional airway approach.

Surgeons then worked their way through the face from the jaw upward in what is known as a "bottom to top approach", using external incisions to fix broken bones, stabilise them with titanium plates and screws, rebuild the eye sockets, reposition the nerves, and restore the overall facial structure. Damaged bone fragments and knocked-out teeth were removed, and the nasal structures were reconstructed to recover both function and appearance.

"This was an extraordinary challenge," said Dr Renju Prem. "Restoring the patient's face and function required meticulous planning, precision, and seamless collaboration across multiple specialities."

US President Donald Trump signalled openness to returning to Pakistan, telling the *New York Post* that talks could resume "over the next two days". "You should stay there... because something could be happening," Trump said, later adding it was "more likely" negotiations would return to Islamabad, praising Pakistan's Field Marshal Asim Munir, Chief of Defence Forces, as "doing a great job".

Diplomatic push

The diplomatic push has also seen Pakistan step up its role. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif is set to begin a regional tour from April 16, visiting Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Turkey as part of efforts to support mediation and stabilise the situation.

Despite the renewed push, deep divisions remain.

Washington has laid down strict conditions, including a complete halt to Iran's uranium enrichment, dismantling of key nuclear facilities damaged in recent US strikes, and the removal of more than 400kg of highly enriched uranium believed to

US-IRAN TALKS BACK ON TRACK FOR SECOND ROUND

Trump: 'Something may happen' in next 2 days

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Diplomatic efforts are intensifying to bring the United States and Iran back to the negotiating table for a second round of talks, with mediators scrambling to revive momentum after last weekend's summit in Islamabad ended without a deal.

Pakistan has proposed hosting fresh negotiations within days, with officials indicating that discussions between Washington and Tehran are ongoing. A diplomat involved in mediation said both sides had agreed in principle to another round, with Islamabad and Geneva under consideration as venues.

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FIRST ISRAEL-LEBANON TALKS SINCE 1993

The first direct talks between Israel and Lebanon since 1993 got underway in Washington yesterday, with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio calling the moment a "historic opportunity" for peace despite deep divisions.

"This is a historic opportunity... to outline a framework for a lasting peace," Rubio said at the State Department, while acknowledging the "decades of history and complexity" behind the conflict.

The rare diplomatic engagement comes amid ongoing fighting between Israeli forces and Hezbollah in southern Lebanon, casting doubt over the prospects for any immediate breakthrough.

The Iran-backed Hezbollah group dismissed the talks as "futile" and urged the Lebanese government to withdraw, while Israel warned of a possible increase in attacks targeting its northern regions during the negotiations.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu reiterated that Israel's goal remains the dismantling of Hezbollah's weapons, while Lebanese President Joseph Aoun said Beirut hopes the talks will deliver a ceasefire and pave the way for broader negotiations. Despite US backing, officials cautioned that expectations remain low given the wide gaps between the two sides.

—S.N.R.

be stored underground. These demands mirror pre-war sticking points that derailed earlier negotiations, with Tehran refusing to give up enrichment rights or transfer its nuclear stockpile. Iran has instead proposed a limited freeze and offered to dilute its uranium under international supervision — positions that fall short of US expectations.

The standoff is unfolding alongside escalating economic and military pressure.

The United States has imposed a naval blockade targeting Iranian oil exports, aiming to cut off a key revenue stream. Officials say the move is designed to force Tehran back to talks under greater pressure, even as Iran argues it retains leverage — particularly through its control over the Strait of Hormuz.

Largely disrupted

The strait, which handles about 20 per cent of global oil and gas flows, has been largely disrupted for weeks, with Iran restricting access and allowing limited transit through con-

trolled routes. Despite the blockade, enforcement challenges have already emerged. Maritime tracking data showed multiple vessels linked to Iran transiting the strait after the blockade came into force, including tankers carrying methanol and cargo ships transporting grain. A Chinese tanker was also reported to have crossed through an approved route.

While a fragile ceasefire reached last week appears to be holding, tensions remain high. Iran has warned it could target US and allied assets across the region, and the unresolved dispute over Hormuz risks reigniting hostilities.

For Washington, the strategy combines military pressure with diplomacy — seeking to push Iran toward concessions while keeping the door open for a broader agreement.

But with both sides holding firm on core demands, the path to a breakthrough remains uncertain as efforts continue to secure a second round of talks.

SEE ALSO P5, 7, 9-12

Early childhood centres to open from tomorrow

Comprehensive safety procedures, approvals required

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

Private early childhood centres in Dubai are set for a gradual return to on-site learning, beginning with those located in government premises and commercial buildings, from tomorrow onwards, the Knowledge and Human Development Authority (KHDA) has announced.

This follows the latest updates issued by the Education, Human Development and Community Development Council earlier yesterday. The Council announced that educational institutions in the country are prepared for a gradual

return to in-person learning, with nurseries set to reopen in phases starting this week.

Priority will be given to nurseries located in government buildings and commercial premises, while others will be allowed to continue providing home-based childcare services under approved regulations, it was announced.

However, reopening of early childhood centres in Dubai will be subject to KHDA approval and in line with comprehensive safety regulations and procedures to ensure a safe and supportive environment for children, KHDA clarified. "The safety and wellbeing of students, staff, and the wider community remain the highest priority. We also encourage everyone to rely on official national sources for information and to avoid circulating unverified news," the authority added.



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